

Understanding Mood Stabilizers

General guidance on mood-stabilizing medications used for bipolar disorder, including lithium and anticonvulsant options, and required monitoring.

What are mood stabilizers used for?

Mood stabilizers are used primarily for bipolar disorder, to treat and prevent both manic/hypomanic and depressive episodes. Lithium is the best-studied option with specific evidence for reducing suicide risk. Certain anticonvulsant medications (such as valproate or lamotrigine) are also used as mood stabilizers.

What to expect

- Mood-stabilizing effect can take several weeks to become fully established
- Regular blood tests are required for lithium and valproate to check the medication level and ensure it stays in a safe, effective range
- Consistency matters — taking the medication at the same time each day, and not skipping doses, helps maintain a stable blood level

Common side effects

- Lithium: increased thirst and urination, mild tremor, weight gain — report any of these to your psychiatrist
- Valproate: nausea, weight gain, hair thinning, tremor
- Lamotrigine: needs a very slow, gradual dose increase to reduce serious skin rash risk

Important safety notes

- Lithium levels are affected by dehydration, some other medications, and kidney function — inform any doctor treating you that you take lithium

Valproate carries significant risk to a developing baby and is generally avoided in pregnancy.

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- Any new skin rash while starting or increasing lamotrigine needs urgent medical review
- Never stop a mood stabilizer abruptly without medical guidance, given relapse risk

When to seek urgent help

Seek urgent medical attention for signs of lithium toxicity (severe tremor, confusion, vomiting, unsteady walking), any new widespread skin rash on lamotrigine, or any new suicidal thoughts.

This material is for patient and family education only and does not replace individualized medical advice. For a personal diagnosis or treatment plan, consult Dr. Kushal Kharel or a qualified mental health professional.

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